Amer entered the harem at Fatehpur Sikri, about whom Salim would write with great affection in his memoir. ‘What shall I write of her goodness and excellence?’ he wrote. ‘She had a mind to perfection and she was so loyal to me that she would have sacrificed a thousand sons and brothers for one hair on my head.’

At the age of fifteen, Salim was growing into a strikingly handsome youth with a faint moustache and a firm jaw. Like his father, he would never grow a beard but he would favour a much more luxurious style in jewels and clothes than Akbar, with elaborately embroidered patkas, jewelled daggers, and a profusion of ornaments and jewellery. Soon after his wedding, Akbar granted Salim full adult status in 1585 and the young prince began assiduously building a corps of noblemen who would be loyal only to him.

The very first missive from the monarch of England, Queen Elizabeth I, arrived in Fatehpur Sikri in the course of the year, brought by a delegation of three English traders representing the ‘merchants of the Levant’ and headed by one John Newbery, accompanied by Ralph Fitch. Elizabeth I addressed Akbar as ‘the most invincible and most mightie prince, Lord Zelabdin Echebar, King of Cambaya’, a sentiment the Mughal Padshah would have appreciated though it is unlikely he ever received the letter. Akbar was at the time busy getting an expedition ready to travel to the Punjab, but he was pleased, nonetheless, to retain the services of a jeweller in the English party, William Leades, to whom he gave ‘a house, and five slaves, a horse, and every day six shillings in money’. The Newbery expedition was the first of many attempts by the English to circumnavigate the Portuguese monopoly of trade in the area. While these adventurers were not able to establish any trade links at this time, they produced the first description of India by an Englishman.

Akbar left Fatehpur Sikri for the Punjab in 1585. When he left, there was no indication that he would never return, and that the great lively discussions of the ibadat khana were forever silenced. The senior members of the harem, including Hamida Banu and Gulbadan, remained in Fatehpur Sikri during Akbar’s endless absence, expecting the Padshah to return any day. Nor was there an abandonment of the city itself, as was later suggested, since many courtiers and harem members remained in the city. Rather, there was a gradual leeching away of its vitality and exuberance, as the Padshah’s absence lengthened to years, and then decades. It has also been proposed